Socius: getting our feelings back to people in an AI-run world

1 Problem & Prioritisation

By 2040, a personal AI agent runs most of our day. I split a life into its two halves, personal and work, and scored each area from 1 (low) to 5 (high). **Relationships came out on top.**

Scoring criteria (informed by the cited research): **Takeover** = how much an agent will run it by 2040 · **Harm** = how badly people are hurt if it fails · **Unsolved** = how little today's tools fix it · **Measurable** = how easily change is tracked.

Area of life (1 to 5)	Half	Takeover	Harm	Unsolved	Measurable	Total
Money and bills	Personal	5	5	2	5	17
Mental health	Personal	3	4	3	3	13
Daily tasks at work	Work	5	3	2	4	14
Learning and skills	Work	4	4	3	3	14
Relationships and friendship	**Personal**	**5**	**5**	**5**	**4**	**19**

Why relationships: highest impact and reach; effort is high but worth it. Banks solve money; nobody guards friendships: when my agent talks to yours, neither of us is there.

SIGNALS TODAY
- Agents run our mail, calendars
- AI-companion downloads +88%/yr
- 1 in 6 people are lonely (WHO)

→

TODAY
Youth spend 35 min a day with friends, 80 with an AI companion.

→

PLAUSIBLE 2040
Friend time halves to ~18 min a day; feelings stay with AI. Preferable: Socius makes it a bridge to people.

Framework: the **Futures Cone** (Hancock & Bezold, 1994; Voros, 2003): probable → plausible → preferable.

2 Target User & Root Cause

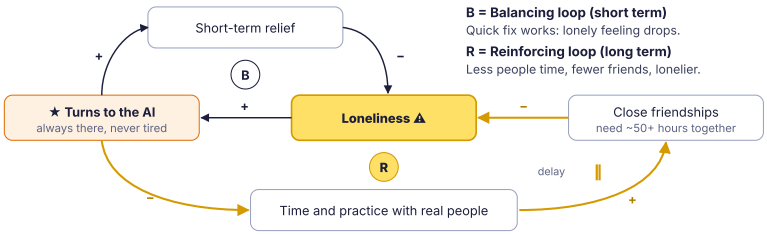
Segment	Situation	Current workaround
Relocated fresher	**Moved cities for a first job; friends far away**	**Vents to the AI, scrolls late**
Remote worker	Days pass without speaking aloud	Agent handles all calls
Hostel student	Crowded, but few close friends; tight budget	Group chats, AI venting
Night-shift worker	Awake while friends sleep; plans never fit	Talks to the AI on breaks

Guesstimate · Today: 1.1 cr grads/yr × 30% relocate × 56% lonely ≈ **18 lakh users/yr. 2040:** every agent user.

Persona: Aarav, from Pune (day 40 in Bengaluru)

Pain point	Intensity	What he wants to improve
P1 · Feelings end up with the AI: late nights with his AI	High	Tell a person, not the AI
P2 · Old friends drifting: they are 840 km away	High	Reconnect with 2–3 old friends
P3 · Nobody nearby: all new faces; does things alone	High	Join a local interest group
P4 · Reaching out feels heavy: cancels plans, scrolls	Med	Make reaching out an easy habit

Root Cause Analysis: the loop that keeps Aarav lonely



How to read it: + = more leads to more, − = more leads to less; odd number of − signs = balancing (B), even = reinforcing (R). Together: the **"Fixes that Fail" archetype**, where the quick fix feeds the long-term problem. ★ **Leverage point:** the "turns to the AI" step, where Socius makes the agent hand him to a person.

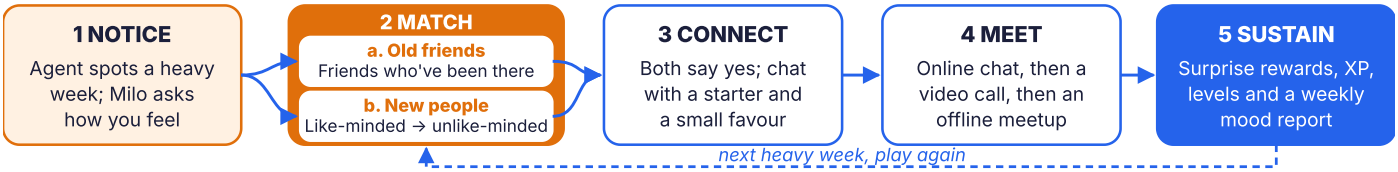
For **a young adult who just moved cities**, when **a hard week hits**, feelings end up with an AI, not a person: **better tonight, lonelier over time**, because **the agent removed the small efforts friendships need**.

3 Solution



Socius is a social game guided by **Milo**, our golden retriever. Your AI agent, running in the background like Gemini and Claude today, is the leverage point: it reads signals such as late nights, and Milo fetches someone who has been there. Plus **Chats**, **Learn** videos, **clan meetups**, an optional **paid coach** and a private **weekly mood report**.

Main user flow



⚠ **Safety first:** if your agent spots signs of a crisis, the game stops and a trusted person you picked earlier is alerted.

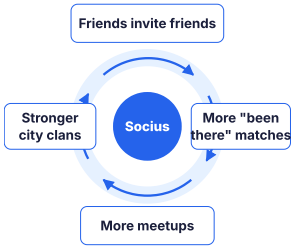
USP 1 · Old friends who've been there
Milo first brings back a friend who went through the same thing.

USP 2 · Level up by showing up
Daily goals, city clans, levels and meetups make reaching out a habit. No one is ever rated.

Operating Model

Like	Hinge's "designed to be deleted", for friends
Matching	Same situation first, old friends first
Signals	Behaviour signals only (late nights, cancelled plans); never chat text
Revenue	Paid coach (Duolingo: 86% subscriptions); colleges and firms pay per seat

Growth loop: each user brings the next



Why users come back

Curiosity: who will Milo find next, like-minded first, unlike-minded later? What will the next level unlock?

Experience: a real talk leaves a warmth no AI reply can match; people return for that, not a streak.

Key Objections

What if they never reply? Rejection hurts the lonely most, so both say yes before any message goes through; a "no" is never shown. And people are gladder to hear from you than you think.

Isn't this profiting from loneliness? Users never pay to connect; colleges and firms do. Youth socialising fell from 1 hour a day to 35 min (2005–2025): skills weaken, isolation grows, people burn out.

Won't Milo become one more AI to lean on? No. AI comfort fades by morning (loop B), so Milo is a bridge: short replies, each ending with a starter for a real person; gems come only when a human replies.

What about privacy? The agent reads only behaviour signals like late nights, never messages. Both must say yes; 18+; delete data anytime.

4 Success Metrics

Metric	Definition
North star	**Emotional moments per week that reach a real person, per active user (shared in your own words, with a reply within 48 hours)**
Supporting	Introductions accepted; friends reconnected; meetups per member; day-60 retention
Guardrails	*Must not get worse while we grow:* Nudges switched off; "felt heard" score; safety false alarms; no individual data to payers
Pilot	8 weeks, 2 Bengaluru campuses vs a waitlist; loneliness measured before and after
Stop signals	*Kill criteria, agreed in advance:* stop or rethink if under 1 in 4 intros are accepted, under 3.3% are active at day 30 (the mental-health app norm), or loneliness doesn't drop.

In 2040 the AI will always be there. Socius makes sure your people are too.

Prototype: claude.ai/artifact/CrXLXFDwXab1k6AXPgpMDh

A Guesstimate: how big is the problem?

Step	Number	Source
Graduates in India each year	1.1 crore	AISHE 2023-24
Move cities for their first job	× ~30% = 33 lakh	Assumption
Feel lonely, safe baseline	× 17% ≈ **5.6 lakh / yr**	WHO: 1 in 6 people [2]
Feel lonely, workplace survey	× 56% ≈ **18 lakh / yr**	Survey of 14 Indian firms, 2025 [6]
People in their first 3 years in a new city	≈ 17–55 lakh at any time	Assumption: 3-year window

Today: 5.6–18 lakh new lonely freshers a year in India alone, so Socius is needed now. The survey notes loneliness is higher among young migrants, so 56% is likely conservative for this group.

2040: young people's time with friends fell from about 60 to 35 minutes a day between 2005 and 2025 [5]. If that trend continues, it is about 18 minutes by 2040. Heavy AI-companion users already spend 80 minutes a day with AI [4], and downloads grow 88% a year [3]. When every agent can comfort us, almost every agent user is at risk, not just movers.

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1 in 6 people are lonely: a "Signals today" statistic.

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20M monthly users, mostly Gen Z, 80 min a day: AI already gets more time than friends.

5 **Axios (2026), from the US American Time Use Survey**
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Ages 15–24 socialise 35 min a day, down from an hour (2005–2025).

6 **Survey of 14 Indian firms (2025), via Insights IAS**
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56% of employees admit loneliness; worse among young migrants.

7 **Hancock and Bezold (1994); Voros (2003): the Futures Cone**
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8 **Hall (2018), Journal of Social and Personal Relationships**
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11 **Baumel et al. (2019), Journal of Medical Internet Research**
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